colourful characters of history; and where Rudyard Kipling found his inspiration for Kim. Contemporaries of the post-Russian revolution period also recognised the continued importance of this region of the world, as the above quote from Lenin shows. As a number of scholars have demonstrated, the Bolsheviks were keenly aware of the benefits of spreading revolution among the discontented Asian masses.[5] An 'Appeal to the Working Moslems of Russia and the East' was among the first declarations made by the party upon seizing power, for example,[6] while at the founding of the Comintern in 1919, there was an awareness that the 'colonial question' needed to be addressed.[7] And, as the chances of revolution breaking out in Europe faded in the years after 1917, so the Bolshevik regime looked increasingly to southern Asia to deliver them from isolation.[8]

Given the state of Asia in the period after the First World War, it is unsurprising that Lenin and his comrades looked keenly at the revolutionary potential there. Nationalist fervour, combined with a resentment against Western imperialism, had been growing among the populations of Asia for some time, and after 1918 would only increase in potency, while Muslim discontent (also apparent before the First World War) was inflamed by the involvement of Turkey in the conflict. Great Asian leaders such as Mahatma Gandhi, Reza Khan and Kemal Ataturk would harness these feelings to initiate mass popular movements within their respective countries, and everywhere in the region the oppressed would start pushing back against their domineering rulers. For Britain, this heady combination of nationalism and pan-Islamism was to provide a particular set of difficulties; for the Bolsheviks, it appeared a perfect opportunity.

For Britain, the complexity of the situation in Asia after the war is exemplified by the creation of the Anglo-Persian Agreement in 1919. The brain-child of Lord George Nathaniel Curzon, this diplomatic arrangement between Britain and Persia was designed to create a stable and secure buffer zone between Soviet Russia and India. British money and expertise was to be used to reform Persia's financial and military structures, which would ultimately protect that country from potential Russian advances from the north. Britain's fear of Bolshevism taking hold in Persia (and subsequently the rest of southern Asia) was a seemingly crucial motivator in the creation